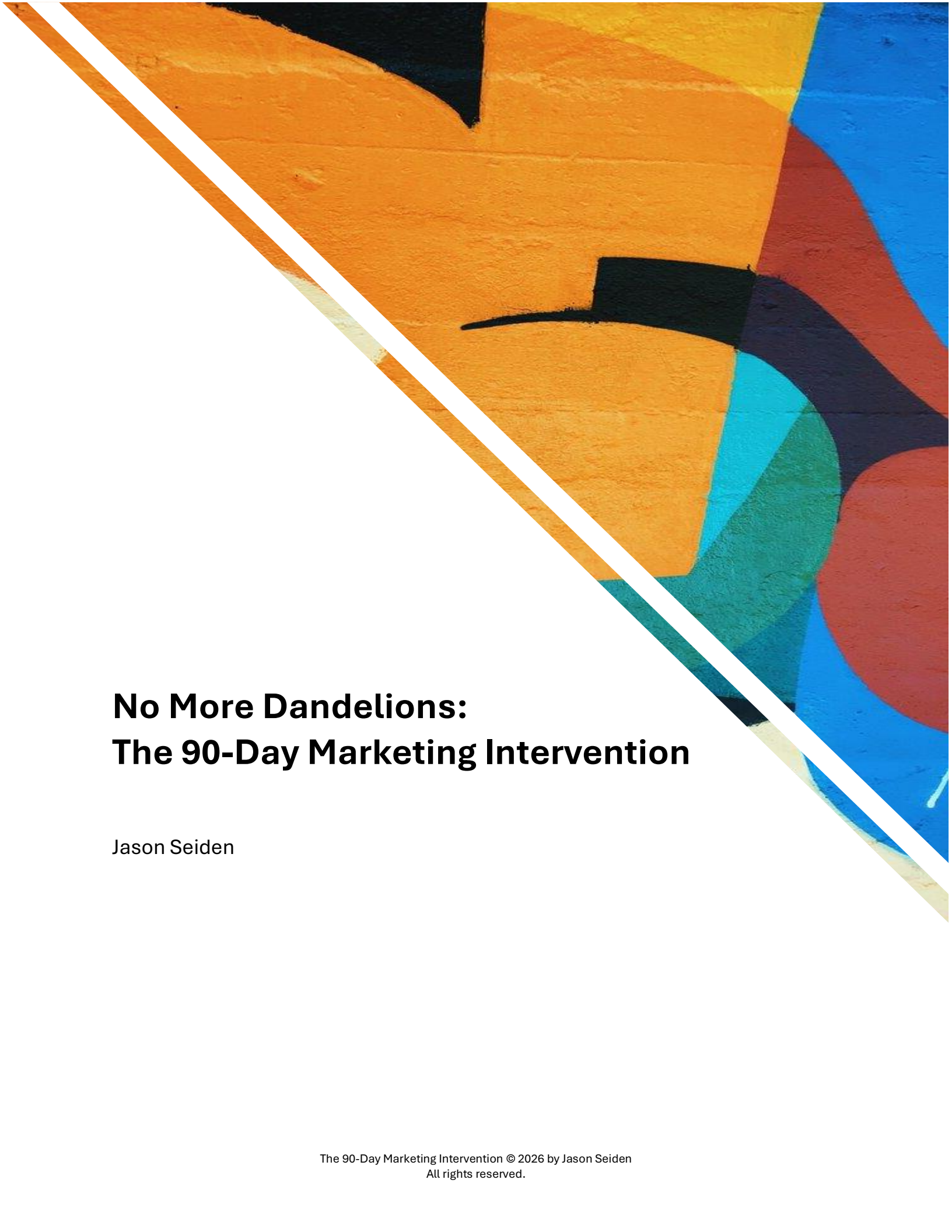




# **No More Dandelions: The 90-Day Marketing Intervention**

Jason Seiden

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# Introduction

Your marketing is broken.

You know it, your team knows it. The board knows it.

You need to fix it. And, you need to transform marketing into an AI-powered machine, with meaningful progress by your next quarterly update.

It's a trap. In a world moving at the speed of AI, the traditional, multi-year transformation roadmap—especially laid atop a broken marketing function—is a suicide pact.

Bain says [12% of corporate transformations achieve their original ambitions](#). Oliver Wyman says [25%](#), BCG [33%](#), McKinsey [31%](#). After spending the last two years reverse-engineering why their own transformation models keep failing, [their latest thinking](#) encourages organizations to embrace “radical reinvention.” McKinsey’s talking about 90-day learning cycles and alternatives to command-and-control leadership. BCG is advocating for the marriage of “wild creativity” and “rigorous discipline.”

They’ve diagnosed the problem beautifully. Late, for sure, but beautifully. What they haven’t done is handed you the manual for fixing it. Because you can understand something thoroughly and still not know the answer to the million-dollar question: *how?* And specifically, *how do you engage in “radical reinvention” when fewer than 3% of marketers are AI proficient* (according to [Section AI](#))?

That’s the question this playbook answers.

If you're facing plummeting engagement rates, rising CAC, or a "True North" that's now shifting depending on who's speaking, you don't have time to relearn transformation from scratch, you need accelerated operationalization of the new model.

This playbook will get you there. It'll help you deliver a jolt of managed entrepreneurialism to your organization, structured to shake things into alignment without breaking them. While the big firms deploy armies of consultants to look at your organization and *suggest* 90-day learning cycles, this playbook shows you how to *bring them to life*. It will take you beyond the white papers about "learner-coach leadership" to show you how to deliver on that idea with truth + empathy.

BCG's data shows that companies with a dedicated Chief Transformation Officer (CTO) are 22% more likely to succeed with their transformation efforts. This is for leaders of growth stage or mid-size companies that either can't afford to devote a full-time CTO to the cause, or can't afford to wait 18 months to find out if the hire was right.

**We're focused on marketing, but the idea is the same: deploy dedicated leadership for a specific period of time who can deliver new outcomes and operationalize the processes used to achieve them.** Along the way, we train your Director of Marketing to sustain the new work so that by Week 12, you don't need the interim leader anymore.

**The first two sections of this book are for CEOs and revenue leaders.** Your team has painted itself into a corner and now somehow you have to *fix* marketing and *upgrade* it at the same time. These sections will help you understand why this mess is so common in business, how to diagnose what's actually broken (vs. what people think is broken), how to activate solutions and keep them moving, and when to bring in outside help vs. fix it yourself.

**The third section is aimed at marketing leaders and teams.** This is your field guide: how to assess what's broken in weeks (not months), how to run experiments that build credibility fast, and how to hand off sustainable systems that don't require you stay forever.

No matter who you are, here's what you'll get:

- Why most marketing transformations fail, how to avoid those mistakes, and why it's hard
- An overview of my 90-day sprint framework for fixing broken marketing
- A way of thinking that will help your team diagnose what's *truly* broken, accelerate fixes, and make things stick
- Examples of what this looks like in action

## How to Use this Playbook

**If you're a CEO or revenue leader**, read Sections 1 & 2 to understand the problem, the solution, and when to bring in help. Skim Section 3 (the deep dive) to get a sense for the tactics and familiarity with the approach.

**If you're a marketing leader or team member**, skim Sections 1 & 2 to understand the strategic context, then focus on Section 3 for the tactical playbook.

**If you're a fractional CMO or consultant**, read the whole thing—this is your playbook for managing both your teams, executive and marketing.

# Section 1: The Foundation

## Setting the Scene

For a minute there, AI really did look like it might be a magic bean. You dared hope for a miracle. (Not that you had much of a choice, I'm sure the pressure from your board was intense.) But now, after a year or more of transition—and despite new vendors, unfamiliar processes, and a smaller team—AI usage is still mostly better search & editing, while significant problems remain:

**Reporting hinges on a manually updated Excel spreadsheet.** A problem with data lake connectivity means a critical report has to be updated by hand. Changes aren't date stamped and the spreadsheet isn't locked, despite broad access. From what you see, about five people usually have it open at a time. You've caught a few errors RevOps missed. *This is taking years off your life.*

**Is PPC an albatross or is it keeping you afloat?** You're not surprised that Marketing and RevOps show different numbers for paid ads. You *are* surprised that one set of numbers suggests a CAC 20x more than your LTV allows, while another suggests PPC performs at an acceptable CAC and accounts for 80% of your online sales.

**The website and e-commerce shopping experiences have degraded to unacceptable levels.** E-commerce has been patched so many times that technical debt prevents all but the most minor of updates. Your shopping cart either has a 70% abandonment rate or reporting is completely cooked. Maybe both. By the looks of it, the last time the site was competitive was 2014.

**Sales leadership believes that reps are being credited for digital sales.** Lead routing logic has gotten so convoluted that no one can unwind it (especially since the person who designed it quit.) GTM budget keeps flowing to sales despite everyone believing marketing's doing the heavy lifting.

**The marketing budget is a horror show.** Thanks to your foray into AI, you've now got tiny startups serving critical functions and you're terrified to find out what happens if they go under. Your agency contracts have overlapping charters and the wrong accountability metrics. Where can you safely cut to get to a manageable CAC/LTV ratio? Where will cutting bring revenue to a halt?

**Customer Marketing has lost the plot.** Marketing is playing small and not working with other departments. They show success every quarter, while Account Management, Customer Success, and Product deliver their own messages to customers. Adoption, support, and net revenue metrics are moving all in the wrong direction.

**As all this has been unfolding, four leaders have cycled through Marketing.** There is no longer anyone who can explain why things are how they are. The people running the day to day have been through so much directional whiplash they stopped paying attention leaders ago.

And the issues just keep piling up, with attempts at fixing things repeatedly blocked by bad data, lack of institutional knowledge, or some unforeseen dependency. It's a perfect storm, and it's hitting at the worst possible time because you need to be moving to AI-level efficiency immediately.

Now marketing is underwater, leadership is frustrated, patience is gone, everyone is looking to someone else for an answer, and nobody knows the right question to ask.

## Why Many Transformations Fail

Failure comes down to a series of compounding problems:

### Dandelioning: The Alignment Problem

No surprise: Oliver Wyman's research pins 75% of transformation failures on "leadership alignment." Not strategy, not technology, not capital—culture. Now here's the surprise: this is a structural problem, not a people problem. Specifically, your True North isn't effectively operationalized.

I know this because I was part of the leadership and communications consulting brigade for the better part of two decades treating it through a talent lens. It wasn't until I became an operating executive that I realized even highly effective leaders run into alignment issues unless they get the structural element right. Without that piece, managers run around trying to "herd cats" and inevitably failing, because they're solving the wrong problem. The real issue?

I call it "dandelioning."

Dandelioning is one of the most common pitfalls I see with management generally, and with change management in particular. Dandelioning is when a singularly focused, top-down directive splinters into multiple department-specific conversations, activities, and outcomes, none of which add up to anything meaningful for the company, but all of which achieve *just enough* success at the departmental level that department managers can't justify killing them.

The CEO wanted everyone to come together to grow a tree. Instead, they got a field of dandelions.

Turns out, the change management model they were given wasn't the most up-to-date version. It had change broken down along departmental swim lanes (those clearly defined areas of responsibility where everyone knows exactly what they own and where their work ends), and integration work limited to a centralized COE or consulting team that most people would never interact with. Explicitly or implicitly, the plan delivered a clear message: focused on your own area.

Meanwhile, the people executing that plan were all human, with a heightened desire to prove their worth because the lack of insight into the anything beyond their department had them afraid for their jobs. So they did what came naturally: they took the idea of the tree—the leader's vision—and

shrank it down until it was something they could manage, end-to-end within their swim lane. A small win, aligned with the vision, that they could take credit for to demonstrate they belonged. In other words, a dandelion. For each department, each team, and each swim lane, a dandelion.

Here's a slightly anonymized example from real life: the CEO challenged the company to use AI to improve customer value by 10%. The head of sales ran ahead, improving customer value by using AI to make the sales hand-off during onboarding run more smoothly. He measured success with a customer survey question: *Did your sales rep stay in contact during your onboarding transition?* He saw a 21% improvement—not bad. The head of customer support also ran to put AI to use, also to improve onboarding, just from the support side. She tracked success by measuring *how quickly CS reps engaged new customers*, and saw a 33% improvement in speed to engagement. Finally, the head of marketing used AI to implement customized customer communication, starting with—you guessed it—a revised onboarding cadence. She tracked success with a survey question about *the quality of the onboarding materials you were provided*. She clocked the 0-to-1 change and set her new baseline at 4.2 / 5.

Each department built a great solution. Each claimed a meaningful win. But they didn't collaborate or connect the dots. They defined and tracked success using department specific terms and metrics. This not only made the company blind to integration challenges, it even made communication difficult: sales talked about customer value as *engagement*, marketing used terms related to *quality*; support turned it into a matter of *responsiveness*. The CEO started with a noble goal and ended up with three dandelions.

As happens with dandelions, the situation gets worse over time. Those disconnected programs already took onboarding from too light to overwhelming. Now with each department collecting feedback in a way that will send them all heading into a positive feedback loop, they'll each justify expanding those small wins, making the customer's overall experience ever more overwhelming with each new change. Sales, marketing, and support are going to celebrate their way to a customer revolt and never see it coming.

We may call it leadership or culture. We may complain about herding cats. But at its root, the issue is structural.

## Watermelons: The Metrics Problem

Green on the outside hiding red on the inside. That's a watermelon. Healthy for a fruit, not so much with metrics. Watermelon metrics occur for a variety of reasons. Some are nefarious, but for the purposes of this playbook, I'm going to assume people are good actors. Below are ways good people end up with false positives in their data:

- **They're too broad or too narrow.** The dandelioning example shows what happens when metrics are assessed at too granular a level. Metrics that are too high level are such a common problem that there's an entire industry devoted to helping executives build dashboards that get them beyond the headline.
- **They're in the middle-distance dead zone.** Right-sized doesn't automatically mean "average." Often, middle-distance metrics are a dead zone—too high level to be of use operationally, not high level enough to indicate directional correctness. "Booth visits" for a conference is a perfect example of a middle-distance metric. If it's high, is that a good

indication of brand awareness, or did you just give away an iPad? Operationally, how does a booth visit count help you understand the impact of your message? A middle-distance metric can be green and you still won't have a clue how the business is doing.

- **They're pure vanity.** Closely related to middle-distance metrics are vanity metrics that indicate relative performance, usually on a social media platform, without any formal correlation to business outcomes. The deeper problem with vanity metrics is that the social media platforms who come up with them are actively looking to conflate "success" on their platform with business success; they're a sales tool, not a diagnostic.
- **They're only applicable to a silo.** Siloed metrics overlap significantly with metrics that are too granular—see the dandelioning example above. But sometimes, a department metric (for instance, top-line revenue) becomes a bellwether for the organization, and when that happens, it can lead to sloppiness elsewhere. The classic example is a focus on growth to the exclusion of the cost to deliver. For instance, I had one client where top-line growth masked the fact that total customer count had fallen nearly by half; at another, the same metric hid the fact that customer success costs had ballooned to over 20% of revenue.
- **They're out-of-date or out-of-touch.** Your competition is destroying you in AEO (getting your content surfaced by ChatGPT, Perplexity, and other AI tools), but your executive dashboard still focuses on SEO, where you look amazing. The lack of AEO metrics leaves you completely exposed to an ongoing shift in market dynamics.
- **They're just wrong.** True story: for months, an executive team struggling with e-commerce challenges sought to address an abandoned carts issue. That was their entire focus. They tried novel marketing campaigns to sales touches, many of which showed promise and became spots of green on an e-commerce dashboard. What they weren't measuring—technical performance—was where the real red was: shopping cart load times were 16-20 seconds and often timed out completely.
- **They're out of context.** Who doesn't want to look good to their boss?! Even people on the up-and-up will sometimes spin bad news or try to cast it as a positive. That's usually not a problem—good managers expect that and know how to "discount" it. But sometimes, managers get busy and forget to push back, and that slightly fudged story becomes *the* story. Oops.

The sprint's diagnostic sophistication (which we'll cover in "How the Sprint Works") is designed to cut through watermelon metrics. The sprint's leader has to know how dashboards lie, and has to have enough empathy to appreciate that the lies are usually not due to dishonesty, but due to yesterday's trade-offs shaping today's reporting. Their job is to look into the white space, ask the questions no one else is asking, and uncover the red hiding under the green.

## Vapor Walls: The "Change with a Lowercase 'c'" Problem

The third major problem with change efforts is that too often, they're lowercase "c" change efforts playing make believe.

Lowercase "c" change is about improving *within set parameters*. Think updates to a car model, new creative for a social media campaign, or change *given* an org structure and set of metrics. Change frameworks that operate at this level may be great for ongoing improvements, but when applied to the "radical reinvention" McKinsey says businesses need, they're straitjackets.

Many corporate change frameworks, like kaizen, are built explicitly for iterative change. Some favorites, like ADKAR, dress up as capital “C” change frameworks but come with too much structure to work for transformational change without significant leadership—their models use centralized planning and top-down communication and lead to dandelioning. Still others, like McKinsey’s 7-S model, do capture the big idea, but they’re so conceptual that as a practical matter, they have to get shrunk down so the people involved can wrap their heads around all the moving pieces. The problem here is that the models require people to use savvy and relationships to undo the limitations built into the process.

How do you know if you’re working at a lowercase “c” level? A big clue is when you have people optimizing processes as opposed to business outcomes. If that’s the case, you’re functioning at a lowercase “c” level regardless of the model you’re using. Another clue: if your Project Management Office loves it, it’s lowercase “c.” Mad respect to the PMO, but if it looks gorgeous in Smartsheets, it lacks sufficient degrees of freedom for radical reinvention.

Which brings me to vapor walls. Vapor walls are habitualized, self-limiting behaviors that prevent people from thinking too creatively or considering major alternatives to the way work gets done. Marketing leaders who use lowercase “c” change models have no way of effectively addressing vapor walls, and so ignore them, or mistakenly believe a little education late in the game will be sufficient for undoing them. That thinking couldn’t be more wrong.

In reality, vapor walls can be harder to remove than real ones. To make the kind of change you’re going for with a transformation, you can’t assume that something that looks like it *should* work based on an org chart and a plan will.

Imagine you’re a flight consultant to a butterfly that’s struggling to fly. You check your lowercase “c” change manual. Best practices pulled together from previous flight consultants lead you to set up a program that makes sure the butterfly has been out of the chrysalis long enough, checks for a broken wing, and then re-trains the little fella on take-off, sustained flight, and landing. Nothing works. You’re baffled; the butterfly *should* be able to do all this without a problem! Down the street, your competitor is using a capital “C” change manual. They approach the butterfly with broader questions. Five minutes later, the butterfly has its foot unstuck from the spiderweb and is on its way.

Vapor walls and lowercase “c” change models reinforce small thinking. It’s frightening to think how many transformations have been permanently stunted in the crib by this combination alone.

## Rehab in a Cast: The Mechanical Problem

Change efforts also suffer from the mechanical problem of trying to get teams to simultaneously fix problems and transform into something greater.

The reason for this is that innocent enough: by the time *transformation* is on the table, a business has been dealing with broken processes for so long that (1) transformation is needed to make the problem go away, and (2) it’s out of runway. Hence the desire to pair long-term transformation with short-term triage.

The issue here is that *fixing* is about applying expertise as fast as possible, while *transformation* is about resetting expertise through measured, thoughtful, and broadly coordinated efforts. **Fixing and transforming are oppositional forces. Asking for both simultaneously pits them against each other.**

Leaders may be tempted to think of the process as complementary, like pairing an aspirin (the fix) with a cast (the transformation). In reality, when things have gotten this bad, the fix isn't an aspirin, it's rehab and movement—and that leg is still in a cast. You need both to heal properly, but you can't do both at once. BCG's research identifies the need for long-term vision and immediate cost right sizing as the "Transformation Paradox." I call it doing rehab in a cast.

## Shiny Objects: The Attention Problem

During times of technological upheaval, shiny objects can become irresistible, for the simple reason that no one wants to be the last to adopt tech that promises a major strategic advantage. Unfortunately, the worst time to go shopping is when you're hungry—that's when discipline is at its lowest. Hype cycles creep into projections. Safeguards get put aside. Expectations explode. And the imperative to resolve existing operational rot lessens. We all know how the story ends.

Hype cycles are inevitable. It's when boards and executives start to build projections based on that hype that they become problematic. Because once projections *require* new tech to perform at its peak, change initiatives are all but doomed.

## Executive Whiplash: The Leadership Problem

The most effective way to train a team to ignore you is to issue a new "edict" every six months.

A new leader comes in and wants to make his mark; he issues an edict, and... nothing. Crickets. He wonders what everybody's problem is.

Turns out, he's the problem. He's the fourth executive in two years to come in and issue an edict, each one completely different from the last. Those people doing nothing? They're exhausted. They're still burdened by tech debt and process debt from the last three executives' edicts. They have no more mental space for anything new and they'd like to just put their heads down and hit their numbers for a change.

They're waiting that new executive out.

## A Better Option: The 90-Day Marketing Sprint

The 90-day sprint is a deliberate alternative to multi-year transformation roadmaps. It's a high-velocity overlap of four phases that help a marketing team outrun organizational inertia for a period to deliver value-creating outcomes. What happens in practice is that things that get in the way of delivering value—CYA sign-offs, nurtures that have been on autopilot for more than a year, personas that haven't been validated since 3 product extensions ago, meetings that really could be emails, reflexive adherence to standard operating procedure—get put on the block, discussed, and—where appropriate—dismantled. Every team carries out-of-date processes that were built to accommodate yesterday's technology, strategy, or team. The sprint provides the jolt of energy needed to overcome fatigue and organizational inertia so these things can be addressed.

Throughout this section, I assume the sprint will be led by a Fractional CMO (FCMO). The reasons for this are laid out in "When to Call for Help" at the end of Section 2.

The sprint phases themselves are designed to prioritize execution through a focus on outcomes, collaboration, and curiosity. The phases are *assess*, *experiment*, *stabilize*, and *handoff*. Note, these are not the typical *assess*, *design*, *execute*, *review* phases executives have been trained to expect. Also, they are not fixed, not run in perfect sequence, and, importantly, they are not executed within swim lanes.

## The Four Phases: A Quick Overview

### Assess

The sprint begins with a brutally honest **Assessment (Weeks 1-4)**. We aren't just looking at dashboards; we're mystery shopping your site, auditing your tech stack, and interviewing your team to find where the bodies are buried.

### Experiment

By Week 2, the focus shifts to **Experiments and Quick Fixes (Weeks 2-8)**. We identify the "low-hanging fruit"—broken routing logic, confusing messaging, or wasted ad spend—and fix it immediately to build credibility and earn the right to tackle bigger goals.

### Stabilize

As experiments are completed and confidence in the data grows, we enter **Stabilizing and Scaling (Weeks 4-10)**. This is where we bridge the silos between Marketing, Sales, and Product, ensuring every department is aligned with your True North. Directionally correct data strengthens as teams share insights and offer feedback on dashboard revisions.

### Hand-Off

The final phase is the **Handoff (Weeks 9-12)**. Far from the typical frantic knowledge dump, this is a controlled transition where assessments, experimentation, and stabilization all continue apace. The only change is that your Director of Marketing and the Fractional CMO you brought in to run the sprint change places, so your Director can lead for a month with the FCMO still actively at their side.

These dates are rough guides. The assessment never truly stops. The handoff starts the first time we delegate to the Director of Marketing, it doesn't wait for Week 9. But while we may not lock down these dates with Type A precision, one thing we can lock down is that tangible improvements in daily workflows will be in place by the end of the first month.

It's amazing what a team can do when exhaustion and whiplash are replaced by the energy of winning.

The 90-day sprint is neither a faster version of traditional transformation programs, nor an excuse to let people implement whatever pops to mind. It's organized, but based on fundamentally different principles—which is why it succeeds where traditional programs fail.

## Why It's Different (And Why that Matters)

Traditional consulting focuses on long-term projections and massive tech implementations. The sprint operates by entirely different rules. Each differentiator below is designed to neutralize a specific failure point that typically sinks marketing transformations.

### Anti-Shiny Object Guardrails

*Addresses the Attention Problem*

During technological upheaval, transformations often fail when a company turns to new technology before fully understanding its potential and limits. Hype cycles and vendor promises are taken at face value, leading to “Frankenstacks” of tools with limited interoperability, projections that require new tech to perform at its peak, and overlapping design/launch workstreams. When this happens, change initiatives are all but doomed.

### **The 90-day sprint is tech-agnostic and reality-first:**

**Process before tech.** One of my teams really wanted to ditch Salesforce for Hubspot. It was, technically, the right call, as Hubspot had several features that would have been a huge benefit to the team. We looked at how our processes were going to change first, asking *why* frequently throughout the process. We found that most of our problems stemmed from having to workaround a ton of bad data—more than 70% of our contacts were duplicates or expired. Jumping to Hubspot wouldn't have fixed that. In fact, it would have made things worse by layering contractual obligations and the need to technically rewire our site and database atop the already messy data situation. Forcing the team to step through the current reality before committing to a new technology helped keep everyone focused on the solutions we needed as opposed to the ones we wanted.

**Front-loaded validation.** The sprint gives data nerds like me a way to ask hard questions *before* technology investment is made. When excitement builds around something like AI and you believe you've found the shortcut to market domination, the sprint provides a way to redirect momentum to give you a chance to validate your idea first. In one company, the head of marketing and head of sales were each researching AI SDR (Sales Development Reps). Marketing's preferred solution was cross-platform, enabling agentic AI across email, chat, text, and phone. Sales fell in love with its preferred vendor—an industry darling!—and signed a contract without consulting with anyone, based on the company's hype and reputation. The problem? The vendor offered a phone-only solution. No cross-channel tracking, no email follow ups, no digital remarketing—just outbound calls. For better or worse, the company now has to deliver results through old school cold calls. Skipping validation led it to buy a partial solution. Frankly, that one still gets to me; although the decision was made outside the scope of the sprint, it was still a self-inflicted injury that I failed to influence.

As long as you adhere to the sprint's principles, the approach will protect you against "Shiny Objects Syndrome" by ensuring that processes get proven out first before technology is used to lock them down and scale them up.

### ***Anti-Whiplash Timeframe & Leadership***

#### *Addresses the Leadership Problem*

The team, exhausted from competing edicts from a rotating cast of leaders, has dug in its heels; they're now ignoring new messaging. They believe that things will change again before they have a chance to finish implementing the new direction, so they're waiting you out. The 90-day sprint breaks this cycle with a structure that shifts from edicts to momentum:

**Leadership is outcome-focused, not politics-focused.** The real beauty of having the sprint run by an FCMO with a time-bound charter is that they get to be focused entirely on outcomes. They can rattle cages, ask dangerous questions, and challenge sacred cows by asking for the data without having to consider the political fallout. An outcome-first, risk-blind FCMO solves a lot of problems.

**90 days is the "Goldilocks" zone.** It's long enough to see marked improvement, short enough to hold a CEO's attention. The finish line is always in sight. Most leadership teams can commit to 90 days, giving change a real shot. Ask people to commit to 18 months and you'll get lip service. What even is 18 months anymore? Ask people to commit to 90 days and you'll get real engagement.

**Trust is earned through action, not PowerPoints.** The FCMO doesn't come in with a "new mark" to make. They start by interviewing everyone—from the Creative Director to the email coordinator—to find where the bodies are buried. By involving the team in the diagnostic process and delivering quick wins by Week 3, they've demonstrated they're not the "fourth leader in two years" with a new set of buzzwords, but the leader who listens and fixes what matters, like that broken routing logic that's giving sales credit for their work.

**People feel the wins, not the grind.** When the team sees tangible improvements in their daily workflow within the first month—when metrics move off Excel into DOMO, PPC spend drops 10% with zero impact on traffic, and landing pages show triple-digit conversion improvements—they stop waiting you out and start leaning in. The exhaustion of whiplash gives way to the energy of winning. This matters not just for business outcomes but for human ones, too—we've all seen too many talented marketers succumb to crossfire from dueling executive orders. Ultimately, the spreadsheet in the business plan won't matter if the people executing are so demoralized and beat down they're just waiting for the next change to drop.

## ***Anti-Watermelons Diagnostic Sophistication***

### *Addresses the Metrics Problem*

The FCMO isn't conducting a six-month audit that has to be finished before anything else starts. They're running rapid-fire diagnostics, shaking off false leads, and zeroing in on what's most critical. The keys to their success: curiosity, data literacy, and interpersonal astuteness.

If today's problems are a function of yesterday's trade-offs—which they are—then those trade-offs are going to impact more than whether a dashboard number trends up or down; they're going to impact what numbers get reported, which are prioritized... and which aren't. For instance, a decision to lean into social media will cause a resource-constrained team to de-emphasize email metrics. Fast forward a year, and social media hasn't taken off like expected.

Teams will often look at the dashboard, see social metrics glowing red, and opt to switch to email. One problem: because of the previous decision to emphasize social media, email insights got pushed into the "white space." The team actually has no idea if email would be any better. Seeing all red can lead a team to jettison the strategy; a more sophisticated view will ask *why* the decision was made to move into social in the first place, *why* the numbers are red, and *what* experiment the team will run to make sure this isn't an execution problem masquerading as a strategic one. In this case, the answer turned out to be that the team was spread too thin across too many social media platforms. Narrowing their focus and using technology to scale the social media manager's reach was all that was needed to turn the numbers around.

The FCMO has to look past what they're being told, into the white space, to address misaligned incentives, poor assumptions, and underpowered processes before making big moves.

**The FCMO goes in expecting the metrics are watermelons.** Their job isn't to figure out *if* numbers are problematic. It's to figure out how to simplify things to bring the team back to a shared focus.

Revealing hidden truths requires a combination of data literacy and interpersonal know-how. The 90-day sprint can't give your marketing leader either (no plan can), but it *can* create space for the FCMO to leverage those two skills with minimal friction. The sprint eliminates top-down, fact-finding interrogations and replaces them with short, focused conversations marked by curiosity, respect, and commitment. Resistance and politics give way to honest conversations. An FCMO engaging in straightforward, blame-free, forward-looking analysis will naturally make it safe for team members to tell the truth.

That's critical: **no trust, no nothing.**

## **Anti-Gridlock Operational Flexibility**

### *Addresses the Mechanical & "Lowercase c change" Problems*

Traditional models treat "fixing" and "transforming" as complimentary steps, which leads to expecting marketing to both go through rehab and rest in a cast at the same time. The sprint recalibrates marketings' thinking to make this a false dichotomy. Focusing on outcomes fundamentally changes the conversation. The sprint is not inherently about fixing or transforming, it's about making the necessary changes to achieve desired outcomes. Experiments start small to make sure the company doesn't rush to deploy complex solutions to problems that can be resolved simply. Complexity gets introduced as needed. This enables a more surgical, case-by-case approach to fixing and transforming.

The *idea* behind this approach is identical to most business processes: review the numbers, make data-driven decisions, act. In practice, the sprint is a different beast. Sprint reporting and experimentation are full contact sports. Everything gets challenged. Most conversations start with *why...*? The sprint leverages familiar ideas but applies them in a way to interrupt set patterns.

Too often, corporate reporting gets stagnant. People get used to seeing the same projects week over week. A pattern develops. Breaking it becomes hard, or even politically dangerous, for no real reason. Self-limiting beliefs take hold: *I want to add something to the report... whose permission do I need to make that change? A fifth week in a row with bad news... I should probably present a solution with the bad news this time, right? That number doesn't make sense... but won't everyone think I'm just trying to make our Golden Child look bad?*

**The sprint recalibrates all of this.** Treating every activity as an experiment makes everything fair game for hard questions. It decouples outcomes from the people running the experiments, making extending or eliminating workstreams politically safe. The dynamism of experiments turns read-outs into participative conversations: *Our email experiment is right at the threshold level for success. Next in the queue is a different email experiment. We need reasons for and against investing another week here versus moving to the next idea.*

That conversation that should be happening already. It probably is, in pockets. The sprint's embrace of experiments just makes it more the norm by continuing to make it safe to engage honestly. This isn't a new-fangled idea about how to run a business; this is back-to-basics leadership that leverages trust, facts, and curiosity to get people leaning into action and honest feedback.

**Flexibility makes it easier to dismantle vapor walls.** To see self-limiting behaviors, a team needs contrast. A standard operating pattern that has become routine offers none. But a dynamic process that invites creatively, open discussion, and cross-team collaborations does provide that. When failure is decoupled from the individual and attached to a 1-week experiment, the team

stops playing it safe, starts asking better questions, and creates a window during which there's an opportunity to shed old habits. This is the way to radical reinvention.

**Small wins earn the right to go after bigger goals.** You can't walk into a broken marketing organization and say, "We're going to rebuild the entire tech stack." But you *can* say, "We're going to deal with the 125k duplicate contacts in our database and the workarounds we have as a result." When that works, you've earned the credibility to tackle the next thing.

The dynamism of rapid experimentation makes it easier to dismantle those ineffective workstreams that have become locked into place, reduces operational complexity, and—best of all—reduces fear. As marketers' ego attachments shift from their specific teams to the overall marketing portfolio, they start to think about experiments in terms of value creation rather than risk mitigation. That tiny shift gets people to use data in entirely different ways—and have more fun doing it.

## ***Anti-Dandelion Collaborations***

### *Addresses the Alignment Problem*

One of the most common outcomes of ill-considered transformations is dandelioning—when a directive for a large, unified push results in a bunch of small, intra-department changes that don't add up to anything meaningful yet can't be killed after they've been implemented. Instead of improving the top and bottom lines, they just drive up the cost of business.

The CEO wanted everyone to come together to build a tree and instead they got a field of dandelions. Why did this happen? Because traditional processes were run along departmental swim lanes, and integration work was owned by a centralized COE (or consulting team) that most people never interacted with.

The sprint puts a premium on cross-department collaboration to make sure successful experiments *stick*. Marketing builds bridges with other groups through rapid, consistent, transparent communication. The assumption is that as other teams learn about the sprint and the experiments marketing is running, it'll spark action across the organization. Outreach to those teams lets go-getters share ideas, data, and experiment results openly and quickly—before splintering can occur.

These conversations are not FYI or CYA—they are operational and purposeful. *We are running an experiment with a new ICP and need product usage data. We are considering a new campaign and would like an analysis of customer service calls. We'd like to highlight 3-5 sales people talking about their favorite features in a video series. We're having success driving traffic with a particular offer, what will it do to the quarter's revenue forecast if we amplify our efforts?*

One of my favorite ways to accelerate this is simple: invite people from other departments to join a marketing team meeting, and give them the floor to ask any question they want of any person they want. Most of these sessions will be fine; the person will share what *they* do and maybe ask a polite question or two. But a few of them will *light the place up*. Product owners, finance managers, and engineers often make great guests. This builds bridges plus creates the contrast needed to reveal vapor walls and spark new thinking.

Asks of other teams are small but meaningful. Asks connect people who are working toward similar goals. And, asks reveal structural and political impediments to cross-departmental work which, once seen, can be addressed.

If you have a centralized PMO, this might sound like the sprint is a way to do an end run around it. That's correct. But! The PMO is invited to the party, too. Ideally, a project manager will embed with marketing during the sprint. This creates the correct relationship between the departments, with marketing providing direction and momentum, and the PMO providing accountability and risk mitigation.

Still, process alone is usually not enough. Collaborations need that FCMO, with their short-term tenure, to get the partnerships to work—first, because other leaders can get behind an fractional leader who's pushing the pace without ceding power to a peer, and second because there *will* be structural impediments to cross-departmental work, and the FCMO can play the villain when it comes time to the bruising work of addressing them.

## The Bottom Line

These five differentiators—anti-shiny object approach, cure for executive whiplash, diagnostic sophistication, operational flexibility, and cross-departmental collaboration—work together to create a system that's fundamentally different from—and the antidote to—traditional transformation programs.

In short, this is an entrepreneurial intervention. It's a way of bulldozing that field of dandelions so you can plant a tree. The sprint will orient marketing to your True North, simplify their metrics with a focus on what actually drives revenue, and get a sustainable operating system stood up that can be handed off after the 90 days of quick wins are up.

These benefits aren't theoretical. Let's look at how they played out in two real world scenarios.

## Section 2: The Sprint in Practice

The following are real-world examples of the sprint in action. You'll recognize these scenarios from "Setting the Scene."

### Case: Is PPC an albatross or is it keeping you afloat?

One set of numbers suggests a CAC 20x more than your LTV allows, while another suggests PPC performs at an acceptable CAC and accounts for 80% of your online sales.

Despite a multi-million-dollar annual budget, no one knew which interpretation was true. We had to address this issue, with the understanding that cutting this Gordian Knot too aggressively risked cratering revenue and opening a door for competitors to chip away at our market share.

### What We Found

I framed my deep dive into the metrics as a quest to understand how the two sets of numbers came to be. I knew where the PPC manager's came from—I got access to our Google account and had an outside expert review our ad portfolio. Top marks. At least I knew the team running our ads was doing a good job.

Then I brought in RevOps. Studied their reporting build. Documented assumptions. Double checked report sources and how data was propagating across systems. The forensic work was enlightening.

In the course of my research, I discovered that the Revenue team was using PPC to boost top of funnel numbers any time product delayed a launch, which was pretty much all the time. The two dashboards came about when something had fallen out of sync during one of those rushed executions. Prior to that, the dashboards were different—one operational, one for leadership. But when the rushes kept coming, everyone had to give up on repairing the sync issue, and two dandelions were born, as PPC and RevOps solved the resulting reporting gaps independent of one another. For the PPC team, their inability to verify traffic numbers led them to focus on percentage changes in portfolio CTR, tracked on a relative basis.

## What We Fixed (And What We Found Next)

Immediately, we used those relative numbers to identify and freeze spending on non-performing channels. This brought spend down 10% with no impact to traffic, and earned us the ability to:

- Experiment improving our estimate of PPC CAC.
- Experiment re-integrating PPC actuals into a full-funnel dashboard.
- Experiment using the PPC budget as a wedge to initiate product marketing changes.
- Experiment using evergreen, organic content to mitigate the impact of product launch delays.

Deconstructing the reports helped me get the data I needed for a more accurate CAC estimate. I built a simple model that assumed *all* ad traffic converted into bookings, which gave us an absolute best-case CAC—that was already problematically high. And since the *best case* was too high, we knew that reality would be worse.

We immediately got to work. We challenged our PPC strategy assumptions one by one. In short order, we were able to reduce ad spend an additional 30%—with nominal impact to lead volume. The process was simple: for each campaign, I asked *why* we were running it and *what if* we didn't. When met with a risk factor, I asked *why* that risk was important to plan for and *what if* it came true. It got a little repetitive. It also led to a complete rethink of our branding and product launch process.

## Making It Stick

Our PPC work triggered two larger, strategic changes:

- **Brand:** The bloat in our ad spend directly reflected the company's give-everything-a-trademarkable-name brand strategy. Turns out, no one had ever looked at the total cost of ownership of having all those product brands. The problem was broader than PPC, too; connecting with people who were impacted by product naming—Legal, Product, Sales, and Strategy—revealed across-the-board frustration with our branding strategy. Operational complexity was everywhere. What started as a PPC experiment became something bigger: a shift to a branded house strategy that saved millions in ad spend and unlocked productivity in multiple departments.
- **Product:** We knew we had to solve the problem of delayed product launches. By starting with metrics, evergreen content, and a look at how streamlined branding would simplify things, we pre-built credibility before we approached Product; they knew we weren't there to point the finger. We showed them what we were spending to fill gaps from delayed launches and what we were doing to mitigate that (PPC was down about 20% when we started these conversations). We showed what we'd learned about our brand strategy and how a different approach simplified things. We shared our organic content backup plan. Then we asked to look at the product marketing process together to find additional opportunities to smooth things out.

By our second meeting, Product came with their own customer usage data and suggested scrapping the existing launch meetings and instead having Marketing join their weekly operational meeting—this would give us earlier insight into launches and, importantly, delays. As all of this happened organically, a structural roadblock began to appear: our launch levels were too complicated. It took an industrial-grade spreadsheet and multiple

meetings just to remind the teams what the requirements were for each launch in progress. This would have been fine for an enterprise, but for a company trying to grow quickly, it was way too much overhead. We eliminated leveling and replaced it with an a la carte approach to product marketing, where the assets to be created for each launch were determined on a case-by-case basis from a set menu. The new approach allowed us to ditch pre-determined actions in favor of things that were easy and impactful. Again, what started as a PPC experiment to get more proactive led to bigger changes, in this case a streamlined product launch process that took us from constant delays to “we just launched 10 new products in a single quarter.”

## The Results

- **40% total reduction in PPC spend with minimal impact on bookings** (10% spend reduction from killing underperforming platforms + 30% from strategic cuts)
- **Integrated workflows** that enabled us to justify a strategic change to our brand strategy
- **Product launch process clean up** that got the PPC team out of reactive ad buys
- **Dashboard focused on cost per booking** that created clarity across all acquisition channels
- **Time to first impact:** 2 weeks (10% spend reduction)
- **Time to full stabilization:** 10 weeks

## The Lesson

This scenario illustrates how teams optimizing for “local” metrics can hide the true cost of given strategy. The PPC team was improving CTR, lowering CPC, and increasing conversion rates month over month while the company bled cash.

The fix ultimately wasn’t better ad content or smarter bidding strategies, it was getting eyes on the right numbers, repairing the product launch process, and streamlining our brand strategy.

Trying to accomplish all that top-down with the typical swim lanes project plan would have been impossible. But in a sprint, with a focus on overall marketing results and an explicit expectation for cross-departmental collaboration, the existing team was able to be their own heroes, addressing things faster than any outside consultant or new hire ever would have.

## Case: Customer Marketing Has Lost the Plot.

**Customer Marketing has lost the plot.** Marketing is playing small and not working with other departments. They show success every quarter, while Account Management, Customer Success, and Product deliver their own messages to customers. Adoption, support, and net revenue metrics are moving all in the wrong direction.

## What We Found

Each department was working to improve gross and net revenue retention numbers independent of one another. No two plans for “driving adoption” lined up. Definitions differed in ways that made alignment hard. People were connected to the True North, but not each other. Classic dandelioning.

Not surprisingly, the customer experience was a mess. Product release notes had grown too dense, customer care had spun up its own consulting arm, customer marketing was selling “coming soon” functionality that support was saying was already available, nobody owned onboarding, and customer communication was overwhelming: some customers had received upwards of 45 emails *per week*.

Complicating things further, the executive dashboard tracked customer usage at the account level—not the end user level—leaving leadership completely blind to customer impact. For instance, an account might receive 1,000 total emails in a week but have 1,500 registered users—hardly cause for alarm if you didn’t know the actual distribution of those emails by end user. With no usable dashboards, I had to work with the company’s data scientists to get the information I needed. Eventually, because I had so many questions, they gave me direct access to query the data lake myself.

## What We Fixed

This was a complex issue so we ran concurrent short- and long-term tracks:

- Experiment: would shorter, more visually appealing release notes with “read more →” links reduce support calls?
- Experiment: would a shared customer communications calendar reduce outbound volume?
- Experiment: would stronger, focused communication between departments (e.g., sharing customer feedback) reduce duplicative efforts?
- Experiment: would measuring user-level adoption reveal additional opportunities?

Revising release notes and creating a calendar were quick activities that did help bring people together, organically leading to better-functioning feedback loops and additional small wins. One unexpected win was the creation of a *literal piece of art*, based on the company’s True North, that was unveiled at SKO and hung at the company’s HQ. That was a fun artifact to help direct.

The big win came after developing user-level adoption metrics. We found big gaps that were immediately actionable, such as end-users’ lack of use of configuration tools. Our largest customers, we saw, were using config tools at the administrative level but not the user-level—something we were blind to when viewing usage at the account level. We hypothesized that if we got managers to configure the product based on their daily workflows, it would reduce customizations and make support more straightforward.

I worked with Marketing, Support, L&D, Product, and Account Management to understand what we were currently doing to get customers to use configuration tools. Turns out, instructions on how to use these features were buried in highly technical, 60- and 90-minute webinars. No wonder they weren’t being used! We developed a campaign to drive adoption of configuration tools based on 3-minute, plain-English, how-to style videos, each focused on helping accomplish a specific goal and written so a viewer could Alt-Tab into the app and take actions as the video played. It was *massively* successful.

## Making It Stick

The level of coordination required to get things to happen in a \$1 billion company was immense. But that level of coordination also ensured things would stick. Process designs, metrics (including the executive dashboard), job descriptions, internal lexicons—everything was on the table. These wins took a lot of hand-holding and a lot of time simply showing up to get new processes to stick.

## The Results

- **90% response rate** to the configuration campaign
- **70% increase in user adoption** of targeted configuration functionality in just 6 weeks
- **Additional adoption of 1.5 “adjacent” configuration tools**, on average, by campaign participants
- **Retired 20% of all open customer-submitted product requests**—targeting configuration functionality addressed multiple customer needs that looked different, but stemmed from the same system limitations
- **Measurable impact on Customer Support costs and GRR** (numbers withheld)

**Time to first impact:** 4 weeks (reduced support tickets from cleaned up release notes)

**Time to full stabilization:** rolling cadence

## The Lesson

This scenario was another case of **when everyone's successful but the company isn't, the answer is going to be in the whitespace—meaning in the numbers *not* being reported, and in the spaces *between* departments.**

The fix wasn't better content or smarter campaigns. It was **securing the mandate to orchestrate a unified customer experience**. And it required new metrics to make the issue visible.

Three other critical lessons:

**You have to get the data right.** Tracking adoption at the account level instead of the user level meant we were blind to the actual problems. Once we shifted to user-level tracking, we saw exactly who was struggling and targeted our outreach accordingly.

**Coordination requires structural support.** The shared calendar was tactical, designed to build awareness early. The real transformation came from expanding team and role charters, which happened later in the process. Without those structural changes, departments would have drifted back to their silos within months.

**Start right away.** Nobody believed that changing the release notes would be a magic bullet. Nonetheless, the action started the conversation and built early momentum.

## When to Call in Help: The “Can We Fix This Ourselves?” Self-Assessment

If you've got the right talent, use this playbook to spark some new thinking and let your people run. But do you? Let's find out.

Answer these five questions honestly:

1. Has your team been “waiting for better data” for more than 3 months?

2. Do you need to fix marketing *and* transform it simultaneously?
3. Are your marketing metrics green but your company metrics red?
4. Is marketing operating in a silo from other departments?
5. Is your team playing it safe instead of taking smart risks?

**If you answered “yes” to 3+ questions:** You need outside help. Your team is either stuck, scared, or structurally blocked.

**If you answered “yes” to 1-2 questions:** You might be able to fix this internally using this playbook. But if you’re not seeing progress in 30 days, bring in help.

Next, we’ll do a deep dive into the playbook itself, so you can see how you got here. In Section 3, you’ll learn:

- How to assess what’s broken using rapid-fire diagnostics
- The axioms that will help you find problematic patterns faster
- How to run experiments that build credibility fast
- How to hand off sustainable systems

## What Success Feels Like

Here’s another way to tell if you’re on track to manage change internally—here’s what success *feels* like:

You’ve trust the numbers coming out of marketing. The team is smiling, despite being overwhelmed. A sense of calm permeates the leadership team; there’s that unspoken sense that success is now inevitable.

New revenue-generating ideas spring up, and when they do, they don’t send people scrambling—marketing and sales and product come to meetings already aware of who from the other departments need to be aware of their work, or engaged. Executive meetings are less dramatic, more transparent... with one exception: where you thought you *might* have performance problems, you now have *unmistakable* friction.

In short, the sprint gives solid performers permission to run as fast as they can while still being responsible stewards for the business... and sends poor performers into a tizzy.

Your job, when you start to experience this, is to not mistake newfound clarity with new problems. If you mistake the sprint as the cause of new problems, you’ll kill the messenger. If you understand that the sprint is bringing existing challenges into the light, you’ll know what to do.

## Section 3: The Playbook Deep Dive

Marketing needs fixing, transformations keep failing. The assignment: you've got 90-days to turn the tide. Let's get into the mechanics of how to make it happen.

This section is for the marketing leaders and teams who need to execute the sprint. Whether you're running it yourself or working alongside a fractional CMO, this section will take you from "why it works" to "how to make it work."

### Assessing: How to See What's Actually Broken

The sprint begins with an assessment, but likely not the kind you're used to. We're not conducting a six-month audit or building a 47-slide deck for the Board. We're not putting on formatting theater—even if offshore talent or AI makes clean up easy. We're running rapid-fire diagnostics, we're figuring out what's *actually* broken versus what people *think* is broken, and we're doing it in days and weeks, not months.

The key to moving this fast is understanding how metrics shape everything. Yesterday's trade-offs don't just impact whether numbers go up or down, they affect which numbers are reported in the first place. They shape how dashboards are built and the way your team talks about success. Everyone is looking at current performance. *Your* job is to look past that, and see where the ghosts of yesterday's decisions still shape how the team thinks—where they put invisible limits on what's possible.

### Metrics Shape Everything: Tearing Down Vapor Walls

People do what gets measured. Not what leadership *expects* or *hopes* for, but what they *measure*. And over time, what people do becomes habitualized, often to the point where doing anything else feels dangerous and wrong.

If the PPC team is measured on CTR and CPC, they'll optimize for CTR and CPC—and they'll continue to do so even when the overall marketing strategy stalls and they see the company starting to burn cash.

These habitualized, self-limiting behaviors are what I call vapor walls, and every company has them. In times of steady performance, they're an asset that help keeps things running smoothly.

But in times of change, they're deadly. What's really tragic is when these habits are shaped by watermelon metrics!

To break down vapor walls, you'll have to address how people are measured, especially related to their compensation. That's at the root of peoples' behaviors. This is true across all your marketing teams as well as all the other teams whose help you'll need.

Fortunately, like dandelions, this isn't a people problem but another systems problem. Even better, vapor walls are dismantled with a shift of perspective. During the assessment phase of the sprint, while you're learning about the business, asking questions that shift peoples' perspectives, expand what's possible, and get everyone dealing in truth will start to erase vapor walls so that when you get to execution, things move more easily. Here's how:

**Look at the structure, not just the numbers.** What's on page one of the dashboard and what's on page three? What gets discussed in meetings and what gets buried in appendices? Reporting structure tells you what the organization values in practice. If there's a risk factor that never gets talked about because it's constantly cut for time, move it to the top of tomorrow's agenda and put a red box around it. Then extend the meeting by 30 minutes to look into other items that are usually cut to see if anything critical is tucked in amongst them. If that's not possible, send a note to the CFO asking for help—whatever it takes to get it noticed.

(I once cut a project short when the CEO and CFO refused to address a key metric central to our ability to succeed. I'd flagged the metric on Day 2. On Day 30 when neither of them had engaged with me to address it despite regular attempts to wave the red flag, I stopped the program. We all earn our gray hair; none of us need to earn it twice.)

**Follow the money.** Where is budget flowing? Does GTM budget keep going to sales even though marketing is driving the leads? Is social media spending a lopsided amount on experimental campaigns? Who owns the PR and event budgets? You'll learn a lot about priorities by looking at how teams are incentivized. You'll also learn a lot by listening to what surprises people about the numbers. I had one CEO who couldn't wrap his head around the company's Google ad budget. Every week, he'd make a snarky comment about how much the team was spending. So I asked him about it. I realized that he was mentally anchored to the last budget he'd had when he'd been directly involved with marketing—which had been more than 10 years earlier. I commiserated: "I get it, I'd love to get 2012 prices for Google ads today. I wish I could pay 2012 prices for dinner tonight, too. Unfortunately I'm stuck paying today's rates, so how do we move forward realistically?" When your CEO has an unrealistic idea for what marketing costs, that's a particularly pernicious vapor wall to have to deal with.

**Ask "why." Ask it again. And again.** When someone tells you "email open rates are down," that's not the diagnosis, that's an opening salvo. Why? "Because customers aren't engaging." Why? "Because they're overwhelmed." Why? "Because we're sending too many emails." Why? "Because every department is sending their own cadence." Why? "Because no one owns the customer communication calendar." Now you've found a path to solving the original problem.

The sprint is perfect for channeling your inner three-year-old because it gives you an excuse to ask "why" as often as you want. The important thing is that you use it to audit *systems*, not *people*. That distinction matters.

## Axioms to Give You a Head Start

When you walk into a broken marketing organization, you're going to hear a lot of opinions about what's wrong. The website is outdated. The tech stack is a mess. The team doesn't have the right skills. Sales isn't following up on leads.

What the team doesn't realize is that before you take action, you're going to assess how much of what you hear is true or merits action. During this period, there will be predictable frustration when you come to conclusions that, in their eyes, don't make sense. Bearing the following in mind will prepare you for these moments and help you pull the team along faster:

### **Axiom 1: The team's approach to budgeting needs to flip 180°.**

In many companies, budgeting is bloodsport. A manager's objective is to maximize their budget relative to their peers, which they do this by achieve enough with their current budget to suggest they're on the precipice of great things... without quite accomplishing those great things. But, oh, if they had just a little more budget! In an entrepreneurial organization, people earn budget by achieving as much as they can with next to no resources and then asking management to pour gasoline on the fire they started. This is the exact opposite of what your team is likely used to. The change is a hidden reason why people who want to embrace experimentation sometimes resist.

### **Axiom 2: If people aren't doing what you want, check how they're being measured.**

I just went over this, but it's worth repeating: when there's a gap between what leadership wants and what's actually happening, there's almost always a metric or incentive blocking change. If it's easy to game the system to protect one's job, inflate one's perceived value, or maximize one's bonus, the metric or incentive being gamed is the first problem you've got to address. When you start messing with metrics, you're messing with the tool they use to get paid and/or establish their spot in the pecking order. If you get backlash from team members, look at how your plans impact their numbers.

### **Axiom 3: Someone in the organization has been trying to alert management.**

You're not the first person to notice the problems you're about to find. Someone on the team has already flagged them. (Maybe multiple people.) They've sent emails, raised it in meetings, mentioned it in passing. They're frustrated and possibly burned out. Find them. They are the keys to understanding the organizational roadblocks you're about to run into. They're also your keys to earning the team's trust. Acknowledging their work puts you in a whole different league relative to leaders who preceded you, treated everyone like idiots, and acted like they were the only ones to have ever noticed marketing's problems.

### **Axiom 4: Product-market-fit drifts over time.**

What worked yesterday won't work today. Your product has evolved, your customers have evolved, your competitors have evolved. Don't assume you still have product-market fit. Also, don't assume that drift is the team's fault. Tight deadlines, fast-changing priorities, and limited resources prevent many teams from doing the ongoing legwork needed to keep PMF current. Over time, even A/B tests will become limited in scope. Avoid blame, just invite the team in to fix the problem now via experimentation and move forward.

### **Axiom 5: Feedback loops exist but are underpowered.**

Most companies have mechanisms for gathering and sharing feedback—think NPS surveys, inter-departmental read-outs, management off-sites, and GTM alignment meetings. Everyone will insist

they work great. Everyone is wrong. I have yet to ever walk into a company with feedback loops functioning as expected. The problem is almost always the same: **people believe delivering the same message to 50 people is the same getting 50 people to hear the same message. It's not.** When people start telling you you're spending too much time on communications, remember that very few people understand the principles of effective communication well enough to appreciate what successful communication truly takes. This is why you're here. Remind your executive peers that while communication may look like priority #2 (after the Emergency of the Day), stronger communication means fewer emergencies.

These axioms will give you a head start in anticipating foundational blockers hiding in budgeting, metrics, organizational dynamics, product-market-fit, and feedback loops, which in turn will help you accelerate progress. Many leaders make the mistake of walking in with assumptions about what the solutions should look like, when knowing where to find the real problems is the truly powerful accelerator. This use of pattern-matching saves time, saves energy, engages the team, and earns trust.

## Where to Go for Good Information

You have four weeks to figure out what's broken. Here's how to make the most of it:

### Week 1: Mystery shop and interview

Before you talk to anyone, experience the product and marketing as a new customer. You only have one chance at getting a genuine first impression, so do it first, before talking with anyone or reading any internal documents.

Go through the entire journey, starting by looking up your category on Google, Reddit, and G2. Ask ChatGPT for help. Snoop LinkedIn and TikTok. (Yes, TikTok.) Sign up for the newsletter. *Read it.* Buy something.

Next, interview everyone in marketing. And I mean *everyone*. Talk to the email coordinator, the event specialist, the content writers, the marketing ops folks. You're learning where the bodies are buried. You're also showing up, earning trust, and assessing execution readiness.

At the end of each interview, ask two questions: "What do you need to be successful?" and "What can I do for you?" If it's reasonable, do it. If you need to get authoritative later, you can. But pull that lever too soon and you'll find yourself being the bottleneck to progress. Build a reputation for yourself and make people want to help you—that's how you can move *fast*.

### Week 2: Look at automations and confirm True North

Review hand-off processes between marketing and sales, down to the literal logic in the systems, if you can access it. How are leads being routed? What qualifies as an MQL? What happens after a lead is passed to sales? When does ownership change? Work with sales to pull sales numbers—conversions, close rates, and velocity—and get familiar with the funnel from end to end. You don't want reports, you want eyes on the actual schema.

Look at customer feedback processes. Review NPS and CSAT results. Read the verbatims. Find out when is feedback collected and the exact questions being asked. What usage analyses exist? Is any of this available by customer segment? How is it being used? This is where you'll start to find vapor walls.

Your next stop is the CEO—not to review your plan, although you’ll probably do that, too, but to confirm the company's True North. "Here's how I'm experiencing the company's True North, based on how it shows up on our site, in online bios, in PR boilerplate, and how people talk about it... Is this right?" If it is, great. If not, course-correct before implementing changes, and figure out why you were off and where the True North itself needs to show up differently so that people can get it right *without* needing help from the CEO.

Share True North with the team. State it in one-on-ones, repeat it on team calls, build a PPT slide for folks to include in their decks. It'll feel weird for a day. Push through and make it happen. People need to internalize it.

What if the True North is awful? Tell the CEO. Also tell them it will likely lessen the staying power of the sprint's impact, though fixing it is beyond scope of a 90-day engagement.

### **Week 3: Connect with other departments**

Talk to Product. What information do they get from marketing? How do they get it? Do they use it? What do they wish they got? Who do they know in marketing?

Talk to Customer Success. What are they hearing from customers? What's working? What's not? Are they coordinating with marketing on customer communications?

Talk to Sales. What's their experience with the leads marketing is sending? Are they qualified? Are they timely? What would make their lives easier? What messages resonate with prospects?

Pro tip #1: As you talk with people in other departments, invite them to join a marketing team meeting, and give them the floor to ask any question they want of any person they want. Most of these sessions will be *fine*; the person will share what *they* do and maybe ask a polite question or two. Those will be valuable in building bridges. But then a few of these sessions will *light the place up*. Product owners, finance managers, and engineers are often great guests!

Pro tip #2: When talking about conversations you've had with people other departments, always use the name of the person you spoke with. It's never *I talked with Product*. It's always *I talked with Amy in Product*. Always. Get your team in the habit of seeing the organization as a collection of individuals.

### **Week 4: Rinse and Repeat**

Nothing new this week, you're already overwhelmed. The first iteration of your new dashboard will be awful, your head of brand will be scared out of their wits and checking in with you every two hours, your counterpart in Product will have started a dandelion project that you will somehow need to rein in, your PR team will be rebuffing you because they're misreading their parasocial relationship with your (admittedly vain) CEO, and you'll be wondering how to approach the head of sales, who you'll believe is going to be a problem.

Keep your head down, grind through those early experiments. Get the data. Everything gets easier when you've got the data. Plus, you're building a data-generating experiment machine where you can get more each week. Use your quieter moments to work through whatever noise you've carried forward from your first three weeks.

# Fixing Things Fast: Running Effective Experiments

As soon as you have a sense for issues that can be addressed immediately and without resources beyond marketing, it's time to start making an impact. This will likely begin in the 2<sup>nd</sup> or 3<sup>rd</sup> week. The marketing team has been living this pain; even if they didn't share it with you when you first showed up, there's a zero percent chance they don't already have a list of ideas worth exploring, and possibly actual activities that got shelved prior to you starting. Make sure these first few experiments are manageable (your team can do them without outside help), de-risked (the changes are things that'll need to be done regardless of what direction the company takes), and leverageable (the outcomes will help you establish credibility and make later changes easier).

Here's where to start:

## Close Strategy Gaps

**Rebuild the marketing dashboard with a laser focus on 1-3 core metrics** that (1) align with True North and (2) move you toward your strategic goal. Demote everything else.

For instance, if the goal is reducing CAC, the dashboard should show CAC at every step of the funnel. If your dashboard shows volume at each step with CAC on a follow-up page, flip it: show CAC on page one, with stage-specific volumes on a detail page. This may sound basic. It is. That's why it comes first.

**Help each area connect to one and only one core metric.** Not every team will plug into the strategic metric directly. Help those teams pick a leading metric to focus on that keeps them aligned with your overall goal.

Aligning metrics is not something you need to get right before you start running experiments. Aligning metrics *is itself* a series of experiments.

## Close Customer Experience Gaps

Your goal right now is to streamline the customer journey as aggressively as possible. Look at your website (homepage, navigation, e-commerce flow), emails (nurture formats, cadences, send times), and social presence (are you on too many platforms? are you replying to comments?). Review any ABM activities and business development support, down to how you show up for events and the gifts and swag you send out.

Depending on your web platform, making changes to the site could be difficult. Consider treating these early experiments like micro-campaigns with their own landing pages. A/B test variations then port winning strategies to the main site.

Regarding emails, don't assume that just because they're being sent that they're any good. *Look at them.* If you wouldn't read your own content, change it. Test CTAs. Confirm cadences to ensure campaigns don't conflict, either with each other or with cadences being sent by individual sales people.

Walk through your event strategy. Are you sending the right people? Building the right relationships? Does your swag match your brand? Quick note: nobody likes polyester shirts, and nobody will remember they won that iPad from your booth; make your giveaways count.

## When All That's Needed Is a Reframe

I once worked with a team that had to solve for diminishing returns on email. Their suggested fix was more personalization, the justification being that customer surveys indicated customers preferred email communications.

I asked why customers had that preference. They showed me the survey they'd used to get customer preferences, and I suggested a small experiment: what if we asked a slightly different question? Our discovery: customers liked email because they were archiving messages unread.

Sometimes, before a situation needs action, it needs a new perspective. When the team saw how a small change to wording begat an entirely different answer to a question, it was like they'd just seen a magic trick. But the shift was about more than how the team saw email, it was about how the team thought of problem solving generally. Being wrong went from a matter of intelligence to a matter of perspective, which made challenging assumptions safe. That one little shift in perspective helped vapor walls between the email, social, paid, and organic teams disappear. Marketing strategy coalesced almost immediately around a common goal.

## Keep Structure at a Minimum

One question that does come up, especially when moving into AI-imbued processes for the first time: *Don't you need formal strategy, policy, training, and approved tools to know what kinds of experiments to run?*

No. I mean yes, but... no. Not yet. Those things are absolutely needed when it comes time to stabilize expectations and keep new habits consistent across teams. But in the experiment phase, the most important thing is to make sure the team knows where the limits are—meaning you don't need a full policy, you need the critical “thou shall nots” that define where out-of-bounds is. The experiment phase is about asking questions and charting a path, not laying down the concrete sidewalk. Besides, if an experiment shows promise, before you lock down the new process, you're going to have the team reach out to InfoSec anyway.

The real question is, *How do you know what the policy should say if you haven't rolled up your sleeves and seen the technology for yourself?* I know just from my experience creating this playbook that the AI policy I *would have* written for myself at the beginning would have been much different than what I'd create after having used the tools and gotten to understand their capabilities in practice. Experiments are about the *art of creation* and zero-to-one change. Formalizing expectations is part of the *science of creation* and scaling wins with consistency. That comes second.

## Stabilizing New Behaviors

Up to this point, you've been actively resisting technical solutions. Now that experiments are getting completed and showing promise, it's time to flip that. Once you've proven the business case, *that's* when it's time to use technology to lock in the gains and scale them.

## ***The Power of Technology***

There are two ways to view technology, as a fix or as an amplifier. The sprint treats technology as an amplifier, period.

Treating technology as the fix sets up conflicts of interest, where marketers feel they can't move forward without it while procurement wants proof ahead of time that the desired tech is the best option. We've all experienced the resulting standoff—and all the ways vendors and eager employees try to find ways to accelerate purchasing, how hype collides with sound judgment, and how those workarounds end up squeezing budgets and forecasts.

But you've done something different. You've aligned everyone's interests. You've made sure you know what problems you're trying to solve and then you've tested possible solutions. And you've done all that before applying technology.

Those experiments? They're your business rules, your use cases. They're the unscalable tests that gives the team a chance to figure things out on a small scale, with low stakes, before bringing vendors, contracts, and engineering resources into the mix. With the experiments under your belt, you're able to make clear asks of others. You know what you need and what you don't. Which means you can start using technology to *amplify* your experiments because you have confidence in the fix you're working to implement.

## ***A New Kind of Collaboration***

The other key element of stabilization is making sure you have the right connection points with other departments. These are make-or-break—if you can't plug your new process in with their processes, you'll either end up with a dandelion, McGeyvering a solution that will sap whatever efficiencies you just created, or abandoning your work altogether. It's like buying a new phone only to discover they changed the adapter type and all the cords you have at home are the old ones.

My lightning cables won't work now because my new phone is USB-C? You know the pain.

But look what you've been doing: by engaging other teams early in the experimentation process and working *with* them to align activities rather than focus on our own little dandelion, you've actually done the pre-work needed to make these collaboration conversations go smoothly. For one, they know what you've been working on. For another, they may have stood up their own processes and will be just as interested in aligning with you as you are with them.

I was once at a small company where product, sales, and marketing were siloed, each working at breakneck pace. None of them could keep up with their workloads. Product in particular was dying, with a 9-month backlog of requests. When I initially pulled product into marketing plans, the head of the team understandably resisted—he had zero time for more meetings. But as soon as he saw our direction, he realized something: his team was taking on work too early. They were putting every marketing request into the queue without understanding which asks were aspirational vs. necessary. By the time we'd prioritized our ICPs and come up with our campaign plans, he'd figured out what work was needed for each ICP as well, so when we shared our finished plans, he was able to *immediately* pivot, slash his backlog, build what we needed... and take a breath.

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In my experience, marketing teams often get these two pieces backward: they're too fast to adopt new tech and too slow to engage their peers in other parts of the business. The first two sprint phases correct that. The stabilization phase is when things will start to feel more familiar for the team—only because there's a better foundation in place, the work goes more smoothly.

## Handing Off: Making It Stick

If you've done everything right, the handoff won't feel like a handoff. By Week 9, the Director of Marketing should be running the system, not learning it. Your job is to make sure they can sustain it without you.

### *What a Good Handoff Looks Like*

By Week 9, you should see:

**The team is adapting.** Did functional teams rebuild their own reporting to align with your simplified dashboard? Did they streamline their updates to align with your executive decks? Did people request new tools or headcount based on your budget deep dive? These things tend to happen organically during a sprint. If they haven't, that's a signal the team hasn't internalized the changes.

**The Director of Marketing is leading the conversation.** By the final weeks of the sprint, most of the handoff should be driven by the Director, not you. They should be telling you what they've learned, what they want to keep doing, what they're worried about backsliding on, and what structural changes they need.

If the Director can't articulate these things clearly, you haven't transferred knowledge, you've created dependency. Start undoing that immediately.

### *The Handoff Checklist*

Use this checklist to verify that the “source of truth” is finalized and the Director is ready to be the keeper of the flame.

#### **Metrics: The simplified dashboard**

- ✓ Line-by-line definitions of what each metric means
- ✓ Links to original sources for source data (not descriptions, links)
- ✓ Written guidelines on how to interpret the data and when to trigger specific actions

#### **Strategy: True North**

- ✓ True North statement is finalized (one sentence maximum)
- ✓ Contextual paragraph finalized (three sentences maximum)
- ✓ Departmental, “nested” True Norths are documented (if applicable)

#### **Operations: Process & Budget**

- ✓ Documentation of the *why* behind key process changes (not just *how*)
- ✓ List of outstanding issues with the data needed to build future ROI cases
- ✓ Standing meeting cadence for blame-free post-mortems or weekly updates is scheduled

#### **Leadership: Director Readiness**

- ✓ Director has articulated what they're worried about the team "backsliding" on
- ✓ Director has identified necessary structural changes (job descriptions, reorgs)
- ✓ Director has successfully explained the methodology to a third party (new hire, peer, or CEO)

### **Stress Test: System Resilience**

- ✓ You took a day off in Week 10—what broke? (And what needs to happen to address it?)
- ✓ Director handled a crisis or made a significant decision without you—how did they think through it?
- ✓ You asked the team: What are you worried about after I leave?" (And what needs to happen to address their concerns?)

### **Moving Forward: What Comes Next**

- ✓ Significant issue not addressed during the sprint (e.g., contract renewals, reorgs)
- ✓ Ongoing experimentation plan
- ✓ Clear points of contact with other departments to stay aligned

### **What Not to Document**

- ✓ Everything you did and why (no one will read it)
- ✓ Detailed SOPs for every task (they'll be outdated in a month; set the parameters and make sure experts have room to *scramble*)
- ✓ Your opinions on every decision (the team must make their own decisions)

## **How to Avoid Backsliding**

There *will* be backsliding, set your expectations accordingly. Here's how to minimize it:

**Keep putting the True North front and center.** If people stop repeating it at the top of every meeting, they'll start drifting back to old behaviors.

**Keep budget conversations entrepreneurial.** The shift from "we need more resources" to "here's what we did with what we had and how more investment would help us build on this win" is fragile. Reinforce it constantly.

**Build techniques that resonate into standard operating procedures.** If the team loves blame-free post-mortems, make them a standing meeting. If overcommunication worked, formalize the weekly update cadence.

**Make the Director of Marketing the keeper of the flame.** They need to be the one who calls out backsliding, not you. If they're not comfortable doing that by Week 12, you haven't finished the handoff.

## **What Success Looks Like**

You'll know the handoff worked when:

- The Director of Marketing can explain the methodology to someone else
- The team continues running experiments without you
- The metrics stay simplified (they don't add back complexity)
- People still reference the True North in decision-making

If those things are happening, you've done your job. The system will outlast your engagement.

## About the Author

Jason Seiden is a fractional executive and strategic advisor who helps leaders fix what's broken in their marketing, in their organizations, and in their approach to change.

Based in Dallas, Texas, Jason brings 30 years of experience to growth-stage and scale-up B2B tech companies. He specializes in marketing operations, technology-led transformation, and in keeping leaders grounded in their humanity. This playbook was built with the help of AI so that it would be shaped by firsthand experience with the technology pressures faced by your teams.

An alumnus of Wharton and Kellogg, Jason has authored two business books, and pioneered the field of employer branding, yet his most profound insights hit at the intersection of structure and empathy. Following the loss of his daughter, Elle, in 2018, he developed Comfort Communications, a framework that helps organizations navigate grief with dignity, predictability, and equity. It's the reminder we need that business success and human joy aren't opposites.

Whether he's streamlining a 90-day marketing sprint or advising on an AI implementation, Jason's mission remains the same: to create a more productive, connected, and joyful world.

**With truth + empathy,  
Jason Seiden**

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